



BOOK 1

Survival Kit

Thirty-three units, ground zero to basic conversation —
one Burmese consonant per unit, from မ to ခ.
Following John Okell's *Burmese by Ear*, one layer at a
time.

By the end of this book you can introduce yourself,
order food and pay, take a taxi, shop and bargain, ask
directions, talk about work and family, handle a health
concern, and hold a full polite conversation in Burmese.

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FOUNDATIONS

UNIT 01 က

Statements & tag questions

က (ka)

Make a simple statement about something, and comment on it the way Burmese speakers actually open small talk — through the weather.

01 • MAIN

● မင်္ဂလာပါ။

Mingalar-ba.

Hello.

● မင်္ဂလာပါ။ ပူတယ်နော်။

Mingalar-ba. Pu-deh-naw.

Hello. Hot today, isn't it.

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ ပူပါတယ်။

Houq-keh, pu-ba-deh.

Yeah, it is.

● ရပါတယ်။

Ya-ba-deh.

That's alright.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-1

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Notice the receptionist opens with Mingalar-ba — that's genuine, but it's not what two Burmese friends say passing each other on the street. Mingalar-ba is a 20th-century coinage, popularized through schools and radio,

and today it lives mainly in formal, service, or foreigner-facing settings — exactly this one. On the street, people mostly skip "hello" entirely and ask a real question instead: Beh thwa-mha-lé? ("Where are you headed?") or Hta-min sa-pi-bi-la? ("Have you eaten yet?") — the same way "how's it going" in English isn't really asking about your wellbeing. Nobody expects a detailed answer to either; "just around" or "not yet" closes the loop fine.

03 • VOCABULARY

မင်္ဂလာပါ mingalar-ba

hello (formal / to foreigners / service settings)

ဘယ်သွားမလဲ beh

thwa-mha-lé

"where are you headed?" — real street greeting

ထမင်းစားပြီးပြီလား

hta-min sa-pi-bi-la

"have you eaten yet?" — real street greeting

ပူတယ် pu-deh

to be hot / it's hot

အေးတယ် é-deh

to be cold / it's cold

ကောင်းတယ် kaun-deh

to be good / it's good

ရတယ် ya-deh

to be all right / it's fine

ဟုတ်ကဲ့ houq-keh

that's right / yes (agreeing)

ဟုတ်တယ် houq-teh

it's true / correct

ကြီးတယ် cí-deh

to be big

ငယ်တယ် ngeh-deh

to be small

04 • GRAMMAR

-deh — the statement ending

Every plain Burmese statement ends in -deh (or -teh after a syllable ending in -q). It's the neutral, all-purpose "is/does" ending — there's no separate word for "to be."

ပူတယ် Pu-deh. It's hot.

ကောင်းတယ် Kaun-deh. It's good.

-naw — inviting agreement

Add -naw to the end of a -deh statement to turn it into a tag question — like English "...isn't it?" Commenting on the weather this way is one of the most common ways to open a conversation in Burmese, the same way English speakers open with "nice day, huh?"

ပူတယ်နော်။ Pu-deh-naw. Hot, isn't it.

ကောင်းတယ်နော်။ Kaun-deh-naw. Good, isn't it.



The anchor loop of the whole script.
Start at the top, curve down and left,
close the loop back where you started
— one continuous stroke.

*See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in
Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.*

UNIT 02



Answering politely

ခ (hka)

Pay someone a compliment and receive one — the polite way, with -ba-/-pa-.

01 • MAIN

● ရေအေးသောက်ပါ။

Yé-é thauq-pa.

Have some cold water.

● ကျေးဇူးတင်ပါတယ်။

Cé-zú-tin-ba-deh.

Thank you.

● ဒီဟိုတယ်ကောင်းပါတယ်နော်။

Di ho-teh kaun-ba-deh-naw.

This hotel is nice, isn't it.

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ သိပ်ကောင်းပါတယ်။

Houq-keh, théiq kaun-ba-deh.

Yeah, it's really nice.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-2

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Being offered a drink the moment you arrive somewhere isn't a special gesture — it's the default. Turning it down flat can read as more distant than intended. If you don't want anything, a soft ma-thauq-jin-ba-bú (Unit 3) plus a reason lands better than silence or a bare no, and it's

completely normal to accept a small amount just to be polite even if you don't finish it.

03 • VOCABULARY

ကျေးဇူးတင်ပါတယ် **cé-zú-tin-ba-deh**
thank you

ကျေးဇူးပဲ **cé-zú-béh**
thanks (casual)

သိပ် **théiq**
very / really

နည်းနည်း **né-né**
a little

ဟုတ်ပါတယ် **houq-pa-deh**
yes, that's correct (polite)

စားတယ် **sa-deh**
to eat

သောက်တယ် **thauq-teh**
to drink

ဟုတ်ကဲ့ခင်ဗျား **houq-keh khin-bya**
yes sir/ma'am (very polite)

04 • GRAMMAR

-ba- / -pa- — the politeness infix

Slot -ba- (or -pa- after a syllable ending in -q) between the verb and -deh to make a statement polite. Pu-deh → Pu-ba-deh. This is the single most useful upgrade you can make to any sentence.

ပူပါတယ် **Pu-ba-deh**. It's hot. (polite)

ကောင်းပါတယ် **Kaun-ba-deh**. It's good. (polite)

Théiq — "very"

Place théiq directly before the verb to intensify it: théiq + kaun-ba-deh = "it's really good." Word order is reversed from English — the intensifier still comes before the verb, since the verb is always last.

သိပ်ကောင်းပါတယ် **Théiq kaun-ba-deh**.

It's really good.



Same loop as ∞, with one extra hook curling off the top right. Draw ∞ first, then add the hook without lifting your rhythm.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

UNIT 03

Saying no

ဂ (ga)

Politely disagree about something everyday — like the weather, again.

01 • MAIN

● ကော်ဖီသောက်မလား။

Kaw-p'i thauq-mala.

Would you like coffee?

● မသောက်ချင်ပါဘူး၊ ကျေးဇူးပဲ။

Ma-thauq-jin-ba-bú, cé-zú-béh.

I don't want any, thanks.

● လက်ဖက်ရည်ရော။

Leq-p'eq-yé yaw.

How about tea?

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ သောက်ချင်ပါတယ်။

Houq-keh, thauq-jin-ba-deh.

Yes, I'd like that.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-3

02 • CULTURE NOTE

A flat "no" is rarer in Burmese than the dictionary form suggests. Ma-...-bú is grammatically correct and genuinely used, but a lot of everyday refusal happens more softly — a reason instead of a refusal ("I'm full" rather than "I don't want it"), a hesitant laugh, or simply

not answering directly. If someone seems to be dodging a clear yes/no from you, that hesitation often is the no.

03 • VOCABULARY

ကြိုက်တယ် *caiq-teh*

to like

မကြိုက်ဘူး *ma-caiq-*

pa-bú

don't like (polite negative)

လိုချင်တယ် *lo-jin-deh*

to want (something)

မလိုချင်ဘူး *ma-lo-jin-*

ba-bú

don't want

နားလည်တယ် *na-leh-*

deh

to understand

နားမလည်ဘူး *na-ma-*

leh-ba-bú

don't understand

ဟုတ်ဘူး *ma-houq-pa-bú*

that's not right / no

ဘူး *-bú*

(negative sentence ending)

04 • GRAMMAR

ma-...-bú — the negative sandwich

Burmese negates by sandwiching the verb: *ma-* goes on the front, *-bú* goes on the end, and the politeness infix *-ba-/pa-* sits in between. *Pu-deh* becomes *Ma-pu-ba-bú* — never just "*pu-deh + not.*"

မပူပါဘူး *Ma-pu-ba-bú*. It's not hot.

ကြိုက်ပါဘူး *Ma-caiq-pa-bú*. I don't like it.

Where *ma-* attaches on two-part verbs

Some verbs are really two syllables glued together (like *ná-leh-deh*, "to understand"). The negative *ma-* goes before the second syllable, not the first: *ná-ma-leh-ba-bú*, not *Ma-ná-leh-ba-bú*.

နားမလည်ဘူး *Ná-ma-leh-ba-bú*.

I don't understand.



A closed loop with a small tail flicked off the base. Round the loop fully before you let the tail trail out to the right.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

UNIT 04 ဃ

Asking a plain question

ဃ (ga (gha))

Point at something and genuinely ask about it — without leading the listener toward an answer.

01 • MAIN

● ထမင်းစားပြီးပြီလား။

Hta-min sa-pí-bi-la.

Have you eaten yet?

● မစားရသေးပါဘူး။

Ma-sa-ya-dhé-ba-bú.

Not yet.

● ဒါဆို ဒီဟာစားသလား။

Da-hso di-ha sa-tha-la.

Then — do you eat this?

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ စားပါတယ်။

Houq-keh, sa-ba-deh.

Yes, I do.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-4

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Pointing at food and asking "do you eat this?" is a genuinely common, welcome question from a visitor — it signals curiosity, not suspicion. If you're offered a taste

of something unfamiliar, trying at least a small amount is read as warmth on your part, even if you don't finish it.

03 • VOCABULARY

-သလာ: -tha-la

(neutral question ending)

-လာ: -la

(neutral question ending, short form)

စားသလာ: sa-tha-la

do you eat (it)?

ကြိုက်သလာ: caiq-tha-la

do you like it?

ရှိသလာ: shi-tha-la

is there.../do you have...?

ဟင့်အင်း hín-ín

no (casual)

ဟုတ်ကဲ့ houq-keh

yes

ဘာ ba

what

04 • GRAMMAR

-tha-la / -dha-la — a genuine question

Unlike -naw (Unit 1), which nudges the listener to agree, -tha-la (voiced to -dha-la after most syllables) is neutral — a real yes/no question with no expected answer either way. It's the natural way to ask about something you're actually unsure of, like whether a food is familiar to someone.

ဒါစားသလာ:။ Da sa-tha-la. Do you eat this?

ကြိုက်သလာ:။ Caiq-tha-la. Do you like it?

ယ

Two loops stacked — draw the lower loop first (like ဝ), then add the second loop directly above it.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in

Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.



UNIT 05 C

Numbers 1–10

င (nga)

Count from one to ten, and use a classifier to ask how many people are in a group.

01 • MAIN

● မနက်စာဘယ်နှစ်ယောက်စားမလဲ။
Ma-net-sa beh-hna-yauq sa-ma-lé.
How many people for breakfast?

● နှစ်ယောက်ပါ။
Hna-yauq ba.
Two people.

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ ခဏလောက်စောင့်ပါ။
Houq-keh, k'a-na-lauq saun-pa.
Okay, please wait a moment.

● ကျေးဇူးတင်ပါတယ်။
Cé-zú-tin-ba-deh.
Thank you.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-5

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Burmese hosts routinely over-cater — more food than the headcount needs is a quiet sign of generosity, not poor planning. If you're asked how many people are

coming and you're unsure, rounding up is safer than rounding down.

03 • VOCABULARY

တစ် tiq

one

သုံး thoun

three

ငါး ngá

five

ခုနစ် k'un-hniq

seven

ကိုး kó

nine

နှစ် hniq

two

လေး lé

four

ခြောက် c'auq

six

ရှစ် shiq

eight

တစ်ဆယ် ta-s'eh

ten

04 • GRAMMAR

Counting needs a classifier

Burmese never counts a noun with a bare number — you always add a classifier (a counting word) after it. -yauq counts people: hna-yauq = "two (people)."

နှစ်ယောက် hna-yauq two people

သုံးယောက် thoun-yauq three people

tiq, hniq, k'un-hniq weaken before a classifier

"One," "two," and "seven" shorten their vowel to a. before most classifiers: tiq-yauq is never said — it's ta-yauq. Same for hniq → hna-, and k'un-hniq → k'un-na-.

တစ်ယောက် ta-yauq one person (not tiq-yauq)

နှစ်ယောက် hna-yauq two people (not hniq-yauq)

C

A single hooked curve — no loop to close. One relaxed stroke, curling from top to bottom-left.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in

Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

UNIT 06 ၀

Numbers & prices

၀ (sa (ca))

Ask the price of something and understand the answer.

01 • MAIN

● ဒါဘယ်လောက်လဲ။

Da beh-lauq-lé.

How much is this?

● ငါးရာကျပ်ပါ။

Ngá-ya caq ba.

Five hundred kyats.

● သိပ်ဈေးကြီးတယ်နော်။

Théiq zé-cí-deh-naw.

That's quite expensive, isn't it.

● ဈေးမကြီးပါဘူး၊ ဈေးချိုပါတယ်။

Zé-ma-cí-ba-bú, zé-cho-ba-deh.

It's not expensive, it's cheap.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-6

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Bargaining is expected at a street market and basically absent at a fixed-price shop or supermarket — reading which kind of place you're in matters more than the specific words. A good-natured, smiling tone throughout the exchange is doing as much work as the numbers;

treating it as a fight rather than a friendly back-and-forth
is the actual foreign-tourist tell.

03 • VOCABULARY

ဆယ့်တစ် s'eh-tiq
eleven

တစ်ရာ ta-ya
one hundred

ဈေးကြီးတယ် zé-cí-
deh
to be expensive

ဘယ်လောက်လဲ beh-
lauq-lé
how much is it?

နှစ်ဆယ် hna-s'eh
twenty

ကျပ် caq
kyat (currency)

ဈေးချိုတယ် zé-cho-
deh
to be cheap

ဒါ da
this / this one

04 • GRAMMAR

beh-lauq-lé — asking a price or amount

Beh-lauq literally means "how much" and takes the -lé question ending you'll formally meet in Unit 7. It's the single most useful phrase for shopping, taxis, and markets.

ဒါဘယ်လောက်လဲ။ Da beh-lauq-lé?

How much is this?

The Voicing Rule

When two words join, the first consonant of the second word often "voices": s'eh ("ten") becomes -zeh in compounds like hna-s'eh (twenty, no change — after a~) but thoun-zeh (thirty, s' voices to z). It doesn't happen after a syllable ending in -q.

သုံးဆယ် thoun-zeh thirty

ရှစ်ဆယ် shiq-s'eh eighty (no voicing — ends in -q)

၈

Begins like a backward c, then flicks upward at the end. Practice the upward flick on its own before joining it to the curve.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

UNIT 07 ဆ

"What" and question words

ဆ (hsa)

Ask an open question using a question word instead of yes/no.

01 • MAIN

● ဒါဘာလဲ။

Da ba-lé.

What is this?

● ဒါထမင်းပါ။

Da hta-min ba.

This is rice.

● ဟိုဟာရော ဘာလဲ။

Ho-ha yaw ba-lé.

And what about that one?

● ဟိုဟာက ဟင်းချိုပါ။

Ho-ha-ga hin-cho ba.

That's soup.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-7

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Asking what a dish is, and where it's from, is genuinely appreciated rather than seen as ignorant — Burmese cuisine varies a lot by region, and locals are often happy

to explain. Complimenting a specific dish by name lands better than a generic "it's good."

03 • VOCABULARY

ဘာ ba

what

ဘယ်သူ beh-thu

who

ဘာဖြစ်လဲ ba-p'yiq-lé

what happened? / what's wrong?

-လဲ -lé

(question-word question ending)

ဘယ် beh

which / where (base)

ဘယ်တော့ beh-dawh

when

ဘယ်လို beh-lo

how

အကြောင်း a-caun

reason / about

04 • GRAMMAR

-lé — closing a question that already has a question word

When your question already contains ba ("what"), beh-thu ("who"), or another question word, you close the sentence with -lé, not -tha-la. The two question endings are never mixed.

ဒါဘာလဲ။ Da ba-lé? What is this?

ဘယ်သူလဲ။ Beh-thu-lé? Who is it?

Question words stay in place

Unlike English, Burmese doesn't move the question word to the front. Ba ("what") sits exactly where the answer word would go: Da ba-lé, literally "this what is?"

ဒါဘာလဲ Da ba-lé?

This — what — is? (What is this?)



A loop with a small tail at the base.

Draw the loop first, then anchor the tail underneath — like  with an added foot.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

UNIT 08

Wanting & asking politely

🔊 (za (ja))

Say what you want, and turn any verb into a polite request.

01 • MAIN

● ဘာလိုချင်သလဲ။
Ba lo-jin-dha-lé.
What would you like?

● ရေလိုချင်ပါတယ်။
Yé lo-jin-ba-deh.
I'd like water.

● ရေပေးပါ။
Yé pé-ba.
Water, please.

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ ရပါတယ်။
Houq-keh, ya-ba-deh.
Sure, no problem.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-8

02 • CULTURE NOTE

You'll often be offered more of something right after you finish it, sometimes more than once, even after you've said you're full — it's closer to a ritual than a real question. A polite, firm ma-lo-ba-bú ("I don't need it")

once or twice is normal and not rude; the offer isn't a test.

03 • VOCABULARY

လိုချင်တယ် lo-jin-deh

to want (something)

ချင်တယ် -jin-deh

(suffix) "want to"

ပေးပါ pé-ba

please give (me)

ရေ yé

water

ထမင်း hta-min

rice

ရတယ် ya-deh

that's fine / no problem

ခဏလောက် k'a-na-

lauq

just a moment

ကျေးဇူးပြု၍ cé-zú-

pyú-ywé

please (formal)

04 • GRAMMAR

-jin-deh — "want to"

Attach -jin-deh directly to a verb to mean "want to [verb]." Sa-jin-deh = "want to eat." It behaves exactly like any other -deh verb — it takes -ba-, -naw, -tha-la, and ma...-bú normally.

စားချင်တယ် Sa-jin-deh. I want to eat.

မစားချင်ဘူး Ma-sa-jin-ba-bú. I don't want to eat.

pé-ba — the all-purpose polite request

Adding pé-ba ("give me," softened) after a verb turns it into a request: "please [verb] for me." You'll use this constantly — ordering food, asking for help, asking for the bill.

ရေပေးပါ။ Yé pé-ba. Water, please.

ကူညီပေးပါ။ Ku-nyi pé-ba. Please help me.



Echoes the shape of *o* with a longer tail underneath. Write *o* first, then extend the tail further down.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in

Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

FIRST NEEDS

UNIT 09 ဈ

When you don't understand

ဈ (za (jha))

Say you don't understand, and ask someone to repeat or slow down.

01 • MAIN

● (မြန်မြန်ပြောသံ)

(fast, natural-speed Burmese)

● ဆောရီး၊ နားမလည်ပါဘူး။

Sáw-rí, ná-ma-leh-ba-bú.

Sorry, I don't understand.

● ပြန်ပြောပေးပါ။

P'yan-pyaw-pé-ba.

Please say that again.

● နှေးနှေးပြောပေးပါမယ်။

Hné-hné pyaw-pé-ba-meh.

I'll speak slowly.

● ကျေးဇူးတင်ပါတယ်။

Cé-zú-tin-ba-deh.

Thank you.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-9

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Struggling with fast, natural Burmese and asking someone to slow down is completely normal, not

embarrassing — most people react with warmth or amusement, not impatience. A visitor making a genuine effort, mistakes included, is generally received far better than one who doesn't try at all.

03 • VOCABULARY

ဆောရီး *sáw-rí*

sorry (English loanword)

ပြန်ပြောပေးပါ *p'yan-*

pyaw-pé-ba

please say it again

မြန်မာလို *myan-ma-lo*

in Burmese

ဘယ်လိုပြောလဲ *beh-lo*

pyaw-lé

how do you say...?

နားမလည်ဘူး *ná-ma-*

leh-ba-bú

I don't understand

နှေးနှေးပြောပေးပါ *hné-*

hné pyaw-pé-ba

please speak slowly

အင်္ဂလိပ်လို *in-ga-leiq-*

lo

in English

နားလည်ပါတယ် *ná-*

leh-ba-deh

I understand

04 • GRAMMAR

Loanwords slot in like native words

Sáw-rí ("sorry") is a straight loan from English, but it takes Burmese grammar exactly like any native word — you can say *Sáw-rí-naw* or ask *Sáw-rí-tha-la*, though the plain form alone is what you'll use most.

ဆောရီးနော် *Sáw-rí-naw*. Sorry (softened).

Building requests with *pé-ba*

P'yan-pyaw-pé-ba ("say again, please") and *hné-hné pyaw-pé-ba* ("speak slowly, please") both use the *pé-ba* pattern from Unit 8 — this is why that pattern is worth over-learning.

ပြန်ပြောပေးပါ။ P 'yan-pyaw-pé-ba .

Please say that again.

နှေးနှေးပြောပေးပါ။ Hné-hné pyaw-pé-ba .

Please speak slowly.

၍

A less common letter today, mostly kept in older spellings. Recognize its shape — a loop with a low, extended tail — more than you'll write it.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

Getting someone's attention

ည (nya)

Politely get a stranger's attention and understand their reply.

01 • MAIN

- ကို အောင် ပါ။ ကူညီပေးရမလား။

Ko Aun ba. Ku-nyi-pé-ya-ma-la.

I'm Ko Aung. Should I help you?

- ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ ကျေးဇူးတင်ပါတယ်။

Houq-keh, cé-zú-tin-ba-deh.

Yes please, thank you.

- ဒီဟာဘယ်လောက်လဲလို့ မေးနေတာလား။

Di-ha beh-lauq-lé-lo mé-né-da-la.

Were you asking how much this is?

- ဟုတ်ကဲ့။ ဒီဟာဘယ်လောက်လဲ။

Houq-keh. Di-ha beh-lauq-lé.

Yes. How much is this?

- ငါးရာကျပ်တဲ့။

Ngá-ya caq-teh.

She says five hundred kyats.

- ကျေးဇူးပဲ၊ ကို အောင်။

Cé-zú-béh, Ko Aun.

Thanks, Ko Aung.

Two things worth noticing here. First, addressing a stranger by a kinship term (a-ma for an older woman, a-ko for a man near your age — Unit 10's vocabulary) rather than a neutral "excuse me" is the actual norm, not an exception. Second, when you need to slip past someone in a crowded space, a slightly lowered head or shoulders while saying kwin-pyu-ba ("allow me") is a common physical gesture of respect, especially near elders or monks — making yourself briefly "smaller" as you pass is doing as much of the politeness as the words are.

03 • VOCABULARY

အမ a-ma

excuse me (to an older woman
/ "auntie")

ရှင် shin

yes? (used by/to women)

ဟုတ်ကဲ့ houq-keh

yes? / I'm listening

ဒီဟာ di-ha

this (thing) here

ကို a-ko

excuse me (to a man about
your age)

ဗျာ bya

yes? (used by men)

ဘာလဲ ba-lé

what is it?

ဟိုဟာ ho-ha

that (thing) over there

04 • GRAMMAR

Getting attention with kin terms

Burmese doesn't have a neutral word for "excuse me" the way English does — instead you address a stranger with a kinship term that fits their approximate age and your gender relative to them: a-ma ("auntie") for an older woman, a-ko ("older brother") for a man near your age.

အမ။ A-ma! Excuse me! (to an older woman)

အကို။ A-ko! Excuse me! (to a man)

Gendered response particles

Shin and bya both mean roughly "yes?" as a reply to being addressed — shin is used by and to women, bya by and to men. You'll hear both constantly in shops and cafés.

ရှင်။ Shin? Yes? (woman)

ဗျာ။ Bya? Yes? (man)

ဃ

Sits low with a long curved tail beneath the line — give it plenty of room below the baseline before you start the next letter.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

UNIT 11



Ordering at a café

ခူ (ta)

Order food and drink at a café or restaurant.

01 • MAIN

- ဒီအနီးမှာကော်ဖီဆိုင်ရှိတယ်။ သွားမလား။
Di a-ni-hma kaw-p'i-s'ain shi-deh. Thwa-mala.

There's a café nearby. Shall we go?

- သွားရအောင်။
Thwa-ya-aun.

Let's go.

- မိနူးကြည့်လို့ရမလား။
Mi-nú cí-lo ya-ma-la.

May we see the menu?

- ရပါတယ်။
Ya-ba-deh.

Of course.

- ဟင်းချိုတစ်ခွက်ပေးပါ။
Hin-cho ta-k'weq pé-ba.

One bowl of soup, please.

- ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ ခဏလောက်စောင့်ပါ။
Houq-keh, k'a-na-lauq saun-pa.

Sure, one moment please.

When a group of Burmese friends goes out to eat, there's often an unspoken understanding about who pays — frequently whoever is older, more established, or hosting. Ko Aung offering to cover the bill next unit isn't generosity out of nowhere; it's closer to a default expectation for him as the local, older friend.

03 • VOCABULARY

မီနူး mi-nú

menu

ဟင်းချို hin-cho

soup

ထမင်း hta-min

rice

ကော်ဖီ kaw-p'i

coffee

ရေခဲမှုန့် yé-gé-hmoun

ice

ခွက် k'weq

bowl / cup (classifier)

စောင့်တယ် saun-deh

to wait

ငတ်တယ် ngaq-teh

to be hungry

04 • GRAMMAR

-lo ya-ma-la — "may I...?"

Attach -lo ya-ma-la to a verb to ask permission — literally "if I [verb], will it be all right?" It's the standard way to ask "may I...?" or "can I...?" in any polite setting.

ကြည့်လို့ရမလား။ Cí-lo ya-ma-la? May I look?

စားလို့ရမလား။ Sa-lo ya-ma-la? May I eat (this)?

Ordering with a classifier

Just like counting people needs -yauq (Unit 5), ordering food needs the right classifier: -k'weq for a bowl or cup. Number + classifier + pé-ba is the whole pattern for ordering anything.

တစ်ခွက်ပေးပါ။ Ta-k 'weq pé-ba.

One bowl, please.

၁၇

A small loop with a flag-like stroke on top — one of the letters borrowed for Pali spellings; you'll meet it more in reading than writing.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

UNIT 12 င

Asking for the bill

င (hta)

Ask for the check and handle a simple payment.

01 • MAIN

● ဘေလ်ပေးပါ။

Beil pé-ba.

The bill, please.

● ငါးရာငါးဆယ်ပါ။

Ngá-ya-ngá-zeh ba.

It's 550.

● ကျွန်တော်ရှင်းမယ်။

Ca-na-w shin-meh.

I'll settle it.

● မလိုပါဘူး၊ ကျွန်တော်ရှင်းမယ်။

Ma-lo-ba-bú, ca-na-w shin-meh.

No need, I'll pay.

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ ဒါဆိုနောက်တစ်ခါ။

Houq-keh, da-hso nauq-ta-k'a.

Alright, next time then.

● ကျေးဇူးတင်ပါတယ်။

Cé-zú-tin-ba-deh.

Thank you.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-12

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Watch for the friendly "fight" over the bill — both people reaching for it, one insisting, the other protesting — it's a real, common social ritual, not awkwardness. Losing that fight gracefully (as Ko Aung does here, agreeing to "next time") is itself part of the etiquette.

03 • VOCABULARY

ဘော့ငွေ saun-di
the bill

ပိုက်ဆံ paiq-s'an
money (colloquial)

အကြွေ a-cwé
change (coins)

ငွေသား ngwé-thá
cash

ငွေ ngwé
money

ချွေတာ c'wé-ta
to save (money)

ငွေလက်ခံသလား ngwé
leq-k'an-tha-la
do you accept card?

အကြွေးဝယ် a-cwé-weh
to buy on credit

04 • GRAMMAR

Numbers keep stacking the same way

550 is ngá-ya-ngá-zeh — literally "5 hundred, 5 tens" — built exactly like the smaller numbers from Units 5–6, just chained together. No new grammar, only more digits.

ငါးရာငါးဆယ် Ngá-ya-ngá-zeh. 550.

da paq-hma — handing something over

Da paq-hma ("here it is," literally "this — put — at") is what you say while physically handing over cash or an item. It pairs naturally with cé-zú-tin-ba-deh in reply.

ဒါပါမှ။ Da paq-hma. Here you go.

ḡ

Pairs with ḥ — another Pali-derived letter. Same small loop-and-flag shape, slightly rounder.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

UNIT 13 ခု

Taking a taxi

ခု (da)

Tell a taxi driver where you're going and settle the fare.

01 • MAIN

- ကျွန်တော်တက္ကစီယာဉ်မောင်းတယ်။ ဘယ်ကိုသွားချင်လဲ။

Ca-na-w teq-ka-si yin-maun-deh. Beh-go thwa-jin-lé.

I drive a taxi. Where do you want to go?

- ရွှေတိဂုံဘုရားကိုသွားချင်ပါတယ်။

Shwé-da-goun p'a-ya-go thwa-jin-ba-deh.

I want to go to Shwedagon Pagoda.

- ဟုတ်ကဲ့။ လေးထောင်ကျပါတယ်။

Houq-keh. Lé-daun ca-ba-deh.

Alright. It costs 4000.

- သိပ်ကြီးပါတယ်။ နည်းနည်းလျှော့ပေးပါ။

Théiq cí-ba-deh. Né-né shaw-pé-ba.

That's a lot. A little discount, please?

- ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ သုံးထောင်ပါပဲ။

Houq-keh, thoun-daun-ba-béh.

Alright, 3000 then.

- ကျေးဇူးတင်ပါတယ်။

Cé-zú-tin-ba-deh.

Thank you.

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Most street taxis don't run on a meter — the fare is agreed before the ride starts, which is why Ko Aung states a price up front rather than waiting until arrival. Negotiating it isn't rude; not negotiating at all is what marks someone as unfamiliar with how it works.

03 • VOCABULARY

သွားတယ် thwa-deh

to go

တက္ကစီ teq-ka-si

taxi

ဘယ်လောက်ကျလဲ

beh-lauq ca-lé

how much does it cost?

လျှော့ shaw

(a) discount

ကား ka

car

-ကို -go

to (a place — direction marker)

ကျတယ် ca-deh

to cost

နေရာ né-ya

place

04 • GRAMMAR

-go — marking where you're going

Attach -go to a place name to mark it as your destination: [place]-go thwa-jin-ba-deh, "I want to go to [place]." This is the same -ko/-go you'll meet again in Unit 15 marking direct objects.

ဈေးကိုသွားချင်ပါတယ်။

Zé-go thwa-jin-ba-deh. I want to go to the market.

Negotiating a price

Théiq cí-ba-deh ("that's a lot") plus né-né shaw-pé-ba ("a little discount, please") is the standard two-line haggling exchange, using théiq from Unit 2 and pé-ba from Unit 8.

သိပ်ကြီးပါတယ်။ Théiq cí-ba-deh.

That's too much.

နည်းနည်းလျှော့ပေးပါ။ Né-né shaw-pé-ba.

A little discount, please.

၃

A rounded loop with a hook trailing to the right — write the loop first, then let the hook flick out lightly.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in

Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

UNIT 14 ပ

Directions inside a taxi

ဃ (da)

Guide a driver in real time — left, right, straight, and stop.

01 • MAIN

● တည့်တည့်သွားရမလား။

Teh-teh thwa-ya-ma-la.

Should I go straight?

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ တည့်တည့်သွားပါ။

Houq-keh, teh-teh thwa-ba.

Yes, go straight.

● ရှေ့မှာဘယ်ဘက်ကိုလှည့်ပါ။

Shé-hma beh-beq-ko lé-ba.

Turn left up ahead.

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့။

Houq-keh.

Okay.

● ဒီမှာရပ်ပါ။

Di-hma yaq-pa.

Stop here.

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ ရောက်ပါပြီ။

Houq-keh, yauq-pa-bi.

Alright, we've arrived.

Giving directions from inside a moving vehicle is typically short and immediate — *teh-teh thwa-ba* ("go straight"), not a fuller polite sentence. The short imperative form isn't brusqueness, it's just what real-time, in-motion Burmese sounds like.

03 • VOCABULARY

တည့်တည့် *teh-teh*
straight ahead

ညာဘက် *nya-beq*
right (side)

ရပ်တယ် *yaq-teh*
to stop

ဟိုမှာ *ho-hma*
there

ဘယ်ဘက် *beh-beq*
left (side)

ကွေ့တယ် *kwé-deh*
to turn

ဒီမှာ *di-hma*
here

ရှေ့မှာ *shé-hma*
up ahead

04 • GRAMMAR

Direction + -ko + verb

Beh-beq-ko lé-ba is literally "left-side-to turn-please" — the same -ko direction marker from Unit 13's -go (they're the same marker; -ko after most syllables, -go after a nasal).

ဘယ်ဘက်ကိုလှည့်ပါ။ *Beh-beq-ko lé-ba.*

Turn left.

ညာဘက်ကိုလှည့်ပါ။ *Nya-beq-ko lé-ba.*

Turn right.

Short, urgent imperatives

In fast real-time situations like a moving taxi, Burmese drops down to bare verb + -ba, without the full -deh sentence — teh-teh thwa-ba, not the longer teh-teh thwa-ba-deh. Short and immediate.

ရပ်ပါ။ Yaq-pa. Stop.

ဆက်သွားပါ။ Seq-thwa-ba. Keep going.

ပ

A rarer letter today, close cousin of ခ. Recognize it in older texts more than you'll need to write it.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in

Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

Shopping: this and that

ဏ (na)

Point at things and ask what they are and what they cost.

01 • MAIN

- ဘုရားဖူးပြီးရင် ဈေးလေးဝင်ကြည့်မလား။

P'a-ya-p'u-pyí-yin zé-lé win-cí-mala.

After the pagoda, want to look at a little market?

- ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ ဝင်ကြည့်ရအောင်။

Houq-keh, win-cí-ya-aun.

Sure, let's go look.

- ဒါဘာလဲ။

Da ba-lé.

What's this?

- ဒါလုံချည်ပါ။

Da longyi ba.

This is a longyi.

- ဟိုဒါကိုကြည့်လို့ရမလား။

Ho-da-ko cí-lo ya-ma-la.

May I look at that one?

- ရပါတယ်၊ ကြည့်ပါ။

Ya-ba-deh, cí-ba.

Sure, go ahead and look.

- ကျေးဇူးတင်ပါတယ်။

Cé-zú-tin-ba-deh.

Thank you.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-15

02 • CULTURE NOTE

You're welcome to pick up and examine items at most stalls without any obligation to buy — handling goods is normal shopping behavior, not a commitment. A shopkeeper re-folding or replacing an item you looked at isn't a signal of annoyance.

03 • VOCABULARY

ဒါ da

this (thing)

ဒီဟာ di-ha

this one

-ကို -ko

(object marker)

လက်စွပ် leq-suq

ring (jewelry)

ဟိုဒါ ho-da

that (thing) over there

ဘယ်ဟာ beh-ha

which one

ကြည့်တယ် cí-deh

to look

ပုဆိုး/လုံချည် longyi

longyi (sarong)

04 • GRAMMAR

da / ho-da / di-ha — three ways to point

Da is the all-purpose "this," ho-da specifically marks something farther away ("that, over there"), and di-ha adds emphasis ("this one right here"). All three work as the subject of a sentence exactly like any noun.

ဒါဘာလဲ။ Da ba-lé? What's this?

ဟိုဒါဘာလဲ။ Ho-da ba-lé?

What's that (over there)?

-ko marking an object

When a verb acts on a specific, identified thing ("look at that one," not just "look"), the object takes -ko. It's optional with vague objects but expected with specific ones like ho-da.

ဟိုဒါကိုကြည့်ပါ။ Ho-da-ko cí-ba.

Look at that one.

𑖦

This letter is Pali-only today — you'll recognize it in loanwords far more often than write it yourself.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.



Bargaining

တ (ta)

Push back gently on a price and reach a number you're both happy with.

01 • MAIN

ဒါဘယ်လောက်လဲ။

Da beh-lauq-lé.

How much is this?

တစ်သောင်းပါ။

Ta-thaun ba.

Ten thousand.

ဈေးနည်းနည်းလျှော့ပေးပါ။

Zé né-né shaw-pé-ba.

A little discount on the price, please.

မရပါဘူး၊ ဈေးဒီလောက်ပဲပါ။

Ma-ya-ba-bú, zé di-lauq-béh ba.

Can't do it, the price is only this much.

ကိုကို ဈေးသင့်အောင်ပြောပေးပါ။

Ko-go zé thin-aun pyaw-pé-ba.

Help him get a fair price.

ဒါဆို ရှစ်ထောင်ပါ။

Da-hso shiq-haun ba.

Alright then, eight thousand.

ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ ဝယ်မယ်။

Houq-keh, weh-meh.

Alright, I'll take it.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-16

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Bargaining among Burmese people is often closer to a friendly game than a confrontation — both sides know roughly where it'll land, and getting there with good humor matters as much as the final number. Having a local friend along, like Ko Aung here, commonly gets a better price than a visitor alone would — not through anything underhanded, just the ordinary "local rate."

03 • VOCABULARY

ဈေးနှုန်း zé-hnoun
price

ရောင်းတယ် yaun-deh
to sell

အရောင် a-yaun
color

အဟောင်း a-haun
old (used)

ဝယ်တယ် weh-deh
to buy

အရွယ် a-ywéh
size

အသစ် a-thiq
new

အနည်းငယ် a-né-ngeh
just a little

04 • GRAMMAR

-meh — the future/intention ending

Weh-meh ("I'll buy it") uses -meh, the future counterpart to -deh: -deh states what is, -meh states what will be or what you intend. It follows the same politeness and negative patterns.

ဝယ်မယ်။ Weh-meh. I'll buy it.

မဝယ်ဘူး။ Ma-weh-ba-bú. I won't buy it.

di-lauq-béh — "only this much"

-béh ("only") attached to a quantity draws a firm line — a shopkeeper using it is signaling the price won't move further, politely but clearly.

ဒီလောက်ပဲ။ Di-lauq-béh. Only this much.

၀

One of the most common letters in the whole script: a flat top, a downstroke, a small foot. Worth drilling on its own before anything else.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

Asking to take a photo

∞ (hta)

Politely ask if you can take someone's photo.

01 • MAIN

- ဓာတ်ပုံရိုက်ချင်ပါတယ်။

Daq-poun yaiq-jin-ba-deh.

I'd like to take a photo.

- ရိုက်လို့ရမလား။

Yaiq-lo ya-ma-la.

May I?

- ရပါတယ်၊ ရိုက်ပါ။

Ya-ba-deh, yaiq-pa.

Sure, go ahead.

- ကျွန်တော် အတူတူရိုက်ပေးမယ်။

Ca-na-w a-tu-tu yaiq-pé-meh.

I'll take one of us together.

- ကျေးဇူးတင်ပါတယ်၊ ကို အောင်။

Cé-zú-tin-ba-deh, Ko Aun.

Thank you, Ko Aung.

- ပြုံးပါ။

Pyoun-ba.

Smile.

- ဟုတ်ကဲ့။

Houq-keh.

Okay.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-17

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Always ask before photographing monks, at religious sites, or people in general — it's taken seriously, not a formality. The reverse also happens often: don't be surprised if locals ask to take a photo with you instead of the other way around, especially outside major cities.

03 • VOCABULARY

ဓာတ်ပုံ daq-poun
photograph

ကင်မရာ kin-ma-ya
camera

ပြုံးတယ် pyoun-deh
to smile

ခွင့်ပြု k'win-pyú
permission

ရိုက်တယ် yaiq-teh
to take (a photo) / to hit

ဖုန်း p'oun
phone

အတူတူ a-tu-tu
together

ဗီဒီယို bi-di-yo
video

04 • GRAMMAR

Chaining -jin-deh and -lo ya-ma-la

You can state your intention (Unit 8's -jin-deh: "I'd like to...") and then formally ask permission (Unit 11's -lo ya-ma-la: "may I?") back to back — very natural, very polite Burmese.

ဓာတ်ပုံရိုက်ချင်ပါတယ်။ ရိုက်လို့ရမလား။

Daq-poun yaiq-jin-ba-deh. Yaiq-lo ya-ma-la?
I'd like to take a photo. May I?

yaiq-pa — a short, warm "go ahead"

The bare imperative yaiq-pa ("[go ahead and] take it") is friendlier and more immediate than a full -deh sentence — appropriate once permission is basically already given.

ရိုက်ပါ။ Yaiq-pa. Go ahead, take it.



∞ is ∞ with a loop added on top.

Write ∞ first, then curl the top stroke into a small loop.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in

Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

UNIT 18 3

Asking the way

ဒ (da)

Ask for and follow directions to a place.

01 • MAIN

● နောက်တစ်နေရာ ဘယ်မှာလဲ။

Nauq-ta-nay-ya beh-hma-lé.

Where's the next place?

● တည့်တည့်သွားပါ။ ဘယ်ဘက်ကိုလှည့်ပါ။

Teh-teh thwa-ba. Beh-beq-ko lé-ba.

Go straight. Turn left.

● ဒီလမ်းလား။

Di-lan-la.

This road?

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ ဒီလမ်းပါ။

Houq-keh, di-lan ba.

Yes, this road.

● ကျွန်တော်ကိုယ်တိုင်လမ်းလျှောက်ချင်ပါတယ်။

Ca-na-w ko-dain lan-shauq-jin-ba-deh.

I'd like to walk there myself.

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ ကျွန်တော်လမ်းညွှန်ပေးမယ်။

Houq-keh, ca-na-w lan-hnyun-pé-meh.

Sure, I'll show you the way.

● ကျေးဇူးတင်ပါတယ်။

Cé-zú-tin-ba-deh.

Thank you.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-18

02 • CULTURE NOTE

When you need to pass in front of someone — stepping past a seated group, cutting across someone's path — a small forward bow or lowered posture while moving through is the everyday version of "excuse me," often doing more work than any phrase. It's especially expected in front of elders or monks, but common enough generally that you'll see locals do it for each other too.

03 • VOCABULARY

ဘယ်မှာလဲ beh-hma-lé

where is it?

နီးတယ် ni-deh

to be close

လမ်းဆုံ lan-zoun

junction

ရပ်ကွက် yaq-kweq

neighborhood

ကြာတယ် ca-deh

to be far / to take long

ကားလမ်း ka-lan

road

တံတား ta-da

bridge

အနီးဆုံး a-ni-zoun

nearest

04 • GRAMMAR

-hma — marking location

-hma attaches to a place or object to mark "at/in/on": Zé-hma = "at the market." It's also how you ask where something is: place-word + beh-hma-lé, "where is [place]?"

ဈေးဘယ်မှာလဲ။ Zé beh-hma-lé?

Where's the market?

ဒီမှာရှိတယ်။ Di-hma shi-deh. It's right here.

ca-deh doing double duty

Ca-deh means both "to be far" and "to take a long time" — the same word covers physical and time distance, the way English sometimes overlaps "far" and "long."

ကြာသလား။ Ca-tha-la?

Is it far? / Will it take long?

3

A rounded loop with a flat base — a softer-edged cousin of ∞.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in

Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

UNIT 19

Near, far, and landmarks

☹ (da)

Describe how close something is, using a nearby landmark.

01 • MAIN

● ဒီကနေ ဘယ်လောက်ကြာမလဲ။

Di-ga-né beh-lauq ca-ma-lé.

How long from here?

● ဆိုင်ဘေးမှာရှိတယ်။ ငါးမိနစ်ပဲ။

S'ain-beq-hma shi-deh. Ngá-mi-niq-béh.

It's next to the shop. Just five minutes.

● ကြာသလား။

Ca-tha-la.

Is it far?

● မကြာပါဘူး၊ နီးပါတယ်။

Ma-ca-ba-bú, ni-ba-deh.

Not far, it's close.

● တံတားနောက်မှာလား။

Ta-da-nauq-hma-la.

Behind the bridge?

● မဟုတ်ပါဘူး၊ ရှေ့မှာပါ။

Ma-houq-pa-bú, shé-hma ba.

No, it's in front.

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ သွားရအောင်။

Houq-keh, thwa-ya-aun.

Okay, let's go.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-19

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Distance and time estimates in casual conversation are often more social than literal — "just a bit further" or "five minutes" can stretch a fair amount in practice. Treat these as reassurance more than precise measurement, the way you might in any language, just more so.

03 • VOCABULARY

ဆိုင် s'ain

shop

ဘေးမှာ beq-hma

next to

ရှေ့မှာ shé-hma

in front of

နောက်မှာ nauq-hma

behind

အထဲမှာ a-t'eh-hma

inside

အပြင်မှာ a-pyin-hma

outside

အောက်မှာ auq-hma

below / under

အပေါ်မှာ apaw-hma

above / on top of

04 • GRAMMAR

Landmark + -hma builds any location phrase

The same -hma from Unit 18 turns any noun into a location word by combining with position words: s'ain-beq-hma ("next to the shop"), ta-da-nauq-hma ("behind the bridge"). Landmark first, position word, then -hma.

ဆိုင်ဘေးမှာ S'ain-beq-hma next to the shop

တံတားနောက်မှာ Ta-da-nauq-hma

behind the bridge



Takes 3 and adds a small hook at the top-right corner — same base loop, one extra flick.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in

Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

UNIT 20 န

Getting around by bus, car, or train

န (na)

Talk about how you're traveling and catch the right transport.

01 • MAIN

● ညနေဆို ဘယ်လိုပြန်ရမလဲ။

Nya-né-hso beh-lo pyan-ya-ma-lé.

In the evening, how do I get back?

● ဘတ်စ်ကားစီးလို့ရတယ်။ ဒါမှမဟုတ် တက္ကစီ
ခေါ်လို့ရတယ်။

Baq-sa-ka si-lo ya-deh. Da-hma-ma-houq
teq-ka-si k'aw-lo ya-deh.

You can take a bus, or call a taxi.

● ဘူတာဘယ်လောက်ကြာလဲ။

Bu-da beh-lauq ca-lé.

How far is the station?

● ဒီကနေ ဆယ်မိနစ်ပဲ။

Di-ga-né sé-mi-niq-béh.

Just ten minutes from here.

● ဒါဆို ဘတ်စ်ကားစီးမယ်။

Da-hso baq-sa-ka si-meh.

Then I'll take the bus.

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ ကျွန်တော်ဖုန်းခေါ်ထားမယ်။

Houq-keh, ca-na-w p'oun k'aw-ha-meh.

Okay, I'll be a phone call away.

● ကျေးဇူးတင်ပါတယ်၊ ကို အောင်။

Cé-zú-tin-ba-deh, Ko Aun.

Thank you, Ko Aung.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-20

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Strangers will often just point or physically walk a short distance with you to show the way, rather than give a verbal string of directions — showing is more common than telling. If someone starts walking alongside you after you ask directions, they're probably helping, not following you.

03 • VOCABULARY

ဘတ်စ်ကား baq-sa-ka

bus

ကား ka

car

ရထား ya-ta

train

တက္ကစီ teq-ka-si

taxi

စီးတယ် si-deh

to ride

ဘူတာ bu-da

station

အငှား a-hnga

rental / for hire

ယာဉ် yin

vehicle (general)

04 • GRAMMAR

si-deh — the one verb for riding anything

Si-deh covers riding a bus, car, train, bike, boat, or elephant — one all-purpose verb, unlike English's drive/ride/take. What changes is the noun in front of it, not the verb.

ဘတ်စ်ကားစီးတယ် Baq-sa-ka si-deh.

to ride the bus

ရထားစီးတယ် Ya-ta si-deh. to ride the train

si-ya-deh — "you catch it (there)"

Adding -ya- before -deh signals possibility/necessity — roughly "[you] get to / need to [verb]." Si-ya-deh, "that's where you catch it," is subtly different from plain si-deh, "to ride."

ဒီမှာစီးရတယ်။ Di-hma si-ya-deh.

You catch it right here.

န

One of the most frequent letters in the script — a loop with a straight tail down the right side.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in

Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

FIRST CONVERSATIONS

Where are you from

○ (pa)

Answer the question every traveler gets asked first.

01 • MAIN

● ခဏနားရအောင်။ ဘယ်ကလာတာလဲ။

K'a-na na-ya-aun. Beh-ga la-da-lé.

Let's rest a moment. Where do you come from?

● အမေရိကန်ကလာပါတယ်။

Ameiq-ka-ga la-ba-deh.

I come from America.

● မြန်မာကို ဘယ်တွေ့လာတာလဲ။

Myan-ma-go beh-dawh la-da-lé.

When did you come to Myanmar?

● ဒီနှစ်ကလာပါတယ်။

Ya-dhiq-pyi-ga la-ba-deh.

I came this year.

● ဒါဆို ပထမဆုံးလာတာပေါ့။

Da-hso pa-t'a-ma-zoun la-da-paw.

So this is your first time, then.

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ ပထမဆုံးပါ။

Houq-keh, pa-t'a-ma-zoun ba.

Yes, my first time.

● ကျေနပ်လား။

Cé-naq-la.

Are you enjoying it?

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ သိပ်ကျေနပ်ပါတယ်။

Houq-keh, théiq cé-naq-ba-deh.

Yes, very much.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-21

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Personal questions that might feel forward elsewhere — where you're from, your age, whether you're married — are asked early and often in Myanmar, and answering them isn't an imposition, it's how people show interest in you. Expect this pattern to keep coming up through the rest of the book; it's not unique to Ko Aung.

03 • VOCABULARY

ပြည် pyi

country

နိုင်ငံ nain-ngan

nation

နိုင်ငံခြား nain-ngan-c'a

foreign

-ကနေ / -ကလာတယ် -

ga / -ga la-deh

from / to come from

အမေရိကန် ameiq-ka

America

ခရီးသည် k'a-yi-thé

traveler

ပထမဆုံး pa-t'a-ma-

zoun

the first time

ခရီးစဉ် k'a-yi-zin

journey

04 • GRAMMAR

-ga — marking where from

-ga attached to a place marks it as a source or starting point: Ameiq-ka-ga la-ba-deh, "I come from America." It pairs with beh-ga la-dha-lé? to ask and answer the same question.

ဘယ်ကလာသလဲ။ Beh-ga la-dha-lé?

Where do you come from?

အမေရိကန်ကလာပါတယ်။

Ameiq-ka-ga la-ba-deh. I'm from America.

U

A closed loop, flat-bottomed — this is the ◯ from the very first example in the Basic Scripts Cheatsheet: ◯ ㄣ = ㄣ◯.

See the *Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell)* in Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

UNIT 22

How long, and first impressions

၅ (hpa)

Talk about how long you're staying and what you think of the place.

01 • MAIN

● ဘယ်လောက်ကြာကြာနေမလဲ။

Beh-lauq ca-ca né-me-lé.

How long will you stay?

● တစ်လပဲနေမယ်။

Ta-la-béh né-meh.

Just one month.

● မြန်မာကို ဘယ်လိုထင်လဲ။

Myan-ma-go beh-lo t'in-lé.

What do you think of Myanmar?

● သိပ်လှပါတယ်။ လူတွေလည်း စိတ်ကောင်းကြတယ်။

Théiq hla-ba-deh. Lu-dwé-léh seiq-kaun-ca-deh.

It's really beautiful. And the people are kind, too.

● ရွှေတိဂုံကို ဘယ်လိုထင်လဲ။

Shwé-da-goun-go beh-lo t'in-lé.

What did you think of Shwedagon?

● အံ့ဩစရာကောင်းတယ်။

An-o-za-ya-kaun-deh.

It was amazing.

● ပြန်လာချင်သေးလား။

Pyan-la-jin-dhé-la.

Do you want to come back again?

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ ပြန်လာချင်ပါတယ်။

Houq-keh, pyan-la-jin-ba-deh.

Yes, I'd like to.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-22

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Warm, general praise of the country ("it's beautiful," "the food is great") is welcomed but sometimes lightly waved off, almost reflexively — a specific compliment about one place, dish, or person tends to land more genuinely than a broad one.

03 • VOCABULARY

နေတယ် né-deh

to stay / to live

ရက် yeq

day

လှတယ် hla-deh

to be beautiful

ပထမဆုံးအကြိမ် pa-

t'a-ma-zoun a-cein

the first time

လ la

month

ထင်တယ် t'in-deh

to think / to guess

စိတ်ဝင်စားတယ် seiq-

win-sa-deh

to be interesting

ပြန်လာချင်တယ် pyan-

la-jin-deh

to want to come back

04 • GRAMMAR

beh-lauq ca-ca — "for how long"

Ca-ca (doubling ca-deh, "to take time") after beh-lauq asks specifically about duration, distinct from beh-lauq-lé (price, Unit 6) — same question word, different follow-up shapes the meaning.

ဘယ်လောက်ကြာကြာနေမလဲ။

Beh-lauq ca-ca né-me-lé?

How long will you stay?

t'in-deh — sharing an opinion

Beh-lo t'in-lé? ("what do you think?") is the natural opener for small talk about impressions — answer it with any adjective-verb you already know: hla-ba-deh, seiq-win-sa-ba-deh, kaun-ba-deh.

ဘယ်လိုထင်လဲ။ Beh-lo t'in-lé?

What do you think?

လှပါတယ်။ Hla-ba-deh. It's beautiful.



㊤ is ㊤ with the top broken open into a loop. Write ㊤, then let the top curl outward instead of closing.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in

Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.



What's your name

☞ (ba)

Introduce yourself and ask for someone else's name — properly, the Okell way.

01 • MAIN

- ဒါက ကျွန်တော့်သူငယ်ချင်း စု ပါ။

Da-ga ca-nawt thu-ngeh-jin Su ba.

This is my friend Su.

- မင်္ဂလာပါ။ နာမည်ဘယ်လိုခေါ်သလဲ။

Mingalar-ba. Nan-meh beh-lo k'aw-dha-lé.

Hello. What is your name?

- ကျွန်တော့်နာမည်က [name] ပါ။

Ca-nawt nan-meh-ga [name] ba.

My name is [name].

- တွေ့ရတာဝမ်းသာပါတယ်။

Twé-ya-da wun-tha-ba-deh.

Nice to meet you.

- ကျွန်တော်လည်း တွေ့ရတာဝမ်းသာပါတယ်။

Ca-na-w-léh twé-ya-da wun-tha-ba-deh.

I'm glad to meet you too.

- စုက ဒီမှာနေတဲ့ ကျွန်တော့်သူငယ်ချင်းပါ။

Su-ga di-hma né-deh ca-nawt thu-ngeh-jin ba.

Su's my friend who lives here.

● ကို အောင်ရော ဘယ်လိုသိကြသလဲ။

Ko Aun yaw beh-lo thi-ca-dha-lé.

And how do you two know each other?

● ဈေးထဲမှာတွေ့တာပါ။

Zé-t'eh-hma twé-da ba.

We met at the market.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-23

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Burmese names don't work like Western ones — there's no inherited family surname passed down, and a name is usually chosen fresh for each child, often tied to their birth day of the week astrologically. The title before a name (Ko, U, Daw, Ma — which you'll meet properly in later books) carries as much social information as the name itself.

03 • VOCABULARY

နာမည် nan-meh

name

ကျွန်တော် ca-na-w

I (man speaking)

တွေ့တယ် twé-deh

to meet

-က -ga

(topic marker — "as for..")

ခေါ်တယ် k'aw-deh

to be called / to call

ကျွန်မ ca-ma

I (woman speaking)

ဝမ်းသာတယ် wun-tha-

deh

to be glad

ခင်ဗျား/ရှင် khin-bya /

shin

you (to a man / to a woman, polite)

04 • GRAMMAR

ca-na-w / ca-ma — "I", by speaker gender

This is BAMA's own letter, and it starts the most personal sentence you'll learn: "I" has two words depending on who's speaking — ca-na-w for a man, ca-ma for a woman. Not a choice; it's fixed by the speaker's own gender.

ကျွန်တော်ကြိုက်ပါတယ်။

Ca-na-w caiq-pa-deh. I like it. (man)

ကျွန်မကြိုက်ပါတယ်။ Ca-ma caiq-pa-deh.

I like it. (woman)

Nan-meh beh-lo k'aw-dha-lé — asking a name properly

Literally "name — how — is called?" This is Okell's own phrasing for "what is your name?" — note k'aw-dha-lé uses the -tha-la/-dha-la question ending from Unit 4, closed by -lé because beh-lo is a question word (Unit 7's rule).

နာမည်ဘယ်လိုခေါ်သလဲ။

Nan-meh beh-lo k'aw-dha-lé? What is your name?



◡ — this is BAMA's own mark, and the first sound in ◡ 𑜋, "Bama." A rounded top over a small loop underneath.

See the *Stroke Practice Sheet* (John Okell) in Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

How old are you

၁၁ (ba)

Ask and answer questions about age.

01 • MAIN

- အသက်ဘယ်လောက်ရှိပြီလဲ။

A-t'eq beh-lauq shi-bi-lé.

How old are you?

- သုံးဆယ့်နှစ်ရှိပါပြီ။

Thoun-zeh-hniq shi-ba-bi.

I'm thirty-two.

- ကို အောင်ကရော ဘယ်လောက်ရှိပြီလဲ။

Ko Aun-ga-yaw beh-lauq shi-bi-lé.

And how old is Ko Aung?

- ငါးဆယ်ရှိပါပြီ။

Ngá-zeh shi-ba-bi.

I'm fifty.

- ငါကတော့ သုံးဆယ်ပဲ ရှိသေးတယ်။

Nga-ga-daw thoun-zeh-béh shi-dhé-deh.

I'm still only thirty.

- စုက ငါ့ထက်အများကြီးငယ်တယ်။

Su-ga ngat'eq a-mya-cí ngeh-deh.

Su's a lot younger than me.

- သုံးယောက်လုံး အသက်မတူဘူးနော်။

Thoun-yauq-loun a-t'eq ma-tu-bu-naw.

None of us are the same age, huh.

● ဟုတ်တယ်၊ ဒါပေမဲ့ သူငယ်ချင်းတွေပါ။

Houq-teh, da-bé-méh thu-ngeh-jin-dwé ba.

True, but we're friends all the same.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-24

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Asking someone's age directly, as Su does here, is completely ordinary — age often determines the kinship terms and level of formality used with someone (whether you're a "Ko," older brother, or "younger" to them), so it's practical information, not a personal question the way it might read in English.

03 • VOCABULARY

အသက် a-t'eq

age

ရှိတယ် shi-deh

there is / to have / to be [age]

အငယ် a-ngeh

younger / junior

အသက်ကြီးတယ် a-

t'eq cí-deh

to be old (in years)

နှစ် hniq

year(s)

အကြီး a-cí

older / senior

-ပြီ -bi

already (change-of-state ending)

ငယ်ရွယ်တယ် ngeh-

ywéh-deh

to be young

04 • GRAMMAR

shi-deh — "there is," "to have," and age all at once

Shi-deh is the general existence verb — "there is," "to have" — and Burmese states age with it: a-t'eq thoun-zeh-

hniq shi-deh, literally "age thirty exists." It behaves like any other -deh verb for negatives and questions.

အသက်ဘယ်လောက်ရှိပြီလဲ။

A-t'eq beh-lauq shi-bi-lé? How old are you?

အသက်နှစ်ဆယ်ရှိပါတယ်။

A-t'eq hna-zeh shi-ba-deh. I'm twenty.

-bi — a change that's already happened

-bi replaces -deh when something has newly become true — shi-ba-bi ("[I] am now...") signals your age as an already-settled fact, not a general statement, subtly different from plain shi-ba-deh.

နှစ်ဆယ်ရှိပြီ။ Hna-zeh shi-ba-bi.

I've turned twenty.

ၾ

ၾ is a large open loop — one of the roomiest letters on the page. Give it space; don't let it collapse into a tight circle.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

UNIT 25 မ

Asking about work

မ (ma)

Talk about what you do for a living.

01 • MAIN

● ဘာအလုပ်လုပ်သလဲ။

Ba a-louq louq-dha-lé.

What work do you do?

● ကျွန်တော် အင်ဂျင်နီယာလုပ်ပါတယ်။

Ca-na-w in-ji-ni-ya louq-ba-deh.

I work as an engineer.

● ကျွန်မကတော့ ဆရာမလုပ်ပါတယ်။

Ca-ma-ga-daw hsa-ya-ma louq-ba-deh.

I work as a teacher.

● ဘယ်မှာလဲ။

Beh-hma-lé.

Where (do you work)?

● ကျောင်းမှာပါ၊ ဒီအနီးမှာပဲ။

Kyaun-hma ba, di-a-ni-hma-béh.

At a school, right nearby.

● ကျွန်တော်ကတော့ တက္ကသိုလ်မောင်းတယ်
ဆိုတာ သိပြီးသားနော်။

Ca-na-w-ga-daw teq-ka-si yin-maun-deh-
hso-da thi-pyí-dha-naw.

You already know I drive a taxi, right.

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ သိပါပြီ။
Houq-keh, thi-ba-bi.
Yes, I know already.

● အလုပ်ကြိုက်လား။
A-louq caiq-la.
Do you like your job?

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-25

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Descriptions of one's own job often undersell it a little — modesty in talking about your own status or achievements is the norm, so a humble-sounding answer may reflect politeness more than the actual scale of what someone does.

03 • VOCABULARY

အလုပ် a-louq
work / job

ကျောင်း kyaun
school

ဆရာ hsa-ya
teacher (male)

အလုပ်ရှင် a-louq-shin
employer / boss

လုပ်တယ် louq-teh
to do / to make

ကုမ္ပဏီ koun-pa-ni
company

ဆရာမ hsa-ya-ma
teacher (female)

အားလပ်ရက် a-la-q-yeq
day off

04 • GRAMMAR

louq-teh — the general verb "to do"

Louq-teh ("to do, to make") is the workhorse for describing any job: a-louq louq-teh ("to do work"), or noun + louq-teh ("to work as [noun]") — hsa-ya-ma louq-ba-deh, "I work as a teacher."

ဆရာမလုပ်ပါတယ်။ Hsa-ya-ma louq-ba-deh.

I work as a teacher.

၆

Three humps in a row — a wave shape, evenly spaced. One of the easier letters to keep consistent at speed.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in

Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

UNIT 26 ယ

Asking about family — married?

ယ (ya)

Ask politely whether someone is married and reply about your own situation.

01 • MAIN

● အိမ်ထောင်ရှိပြီလား။

Ein-daun shi-bi-la.

Are you married?

● မရှိသေးပါဘူး။

Ma-shi-dhé-ba-bú.

Not yet.

● ကို အောင်ကတော့ အိမ်ထောင်ရှိပြီ။

Ko Aun-ga-daw ein-daun shi-bi.

Ko Aung is married already.

● ဟုတ်တယ်၊ ဇနီးရှိတယ်။

Houq-teh, za-ni shi-deh.

Right, I have a wife.

● သားသမီးရှိသလား။

Tha-tha-mi shi-tha-la.

Do you have children?

● နှစ်ယောက်ရှိပါတယ်။

Hna-yauq shi-ba-deh.

I have two.

● ငါ့ကျတော့ လူပျိုပဲ။
Nga-ga-daw lu-pyo-béh.
As for me, still single.

● အားလုံးအခြေအနေမတူဘူးနော်။
A-loun a-jé-a-né ma-tu-bú-naw.
Everyone's situation is different, huh.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-26

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Like age, marital status is asked early and directly — again, out of genuine social interest and because it shapes how people relate to you, not because it's considered private the way it might be elsewhere.

03 • VOCABULARY

အိမ်ထောင် ein-daun
marriage / household

ခင်ပွန်း khin-poun
husband

တစ်ယောက် ta-yauq
one (person)

လူပျို lu-pyo
unmarried man

ဇနီး za-ni
wife

သားသမီး tha-tha-mi
children (son/daughter,
general)

အပျို a-pyo
unmarried woman

မိသားစု mi-tha-su
family

04 • GRAMMAR

shi-tha-la vs shi-bi-la

Shi-tha-la (Unit 4's neutral question) simply asks "do you have?" Shi-bi-la adds -bi (Unit 24's change-of-state marker) — "are you [now, already]?" — the natural form for asking about marriage or age, since both describe a settled state.

အိမ်ထောင်ရှိပြီလား။ Ein-daun shi-bi-la?

Are you (already) married?

ယ

A tall stroke with a loop at the base.

Draw top to bottom first, then close the loop at the foot.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in

Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

UNIT 27 ရ

Parents and siblings

ရ (ya (ra))

Talk about your parents and brothers and sisters, using the real kinship words.

01 • MAIN

● မောင်နှမရှိသလား။

Maun-hna-ma shi-tha-la.

Do you have siblings?

● သုံးယောက်ရှိပါတယ်။

Thoun-yauq shi-ba-deh.

I have three.

● အဖေအမေရှိသေးသလား။

A-p'é-a-mé shi-dhé-dha-la.

Are your parents still alive?

● ရှိသေးပါတယ်၊ ရွာမှာနေတယ်။

Shi-dhé-ba-deh, ywa-hma né-deh.

Still living, they live in the village.

● ငါ့ကျတော့ အစ်ကိုတစ်ယောက်ပဲရှိတယ်။

Nga-ga-daw a-ko-ta-yauq-béh shi-deh.

I only have one older brother.

● ရန်ကုန်မှာနေလား။

Yan-goun-hma né-la.

Does he live in Yangon?

● မဟုတ်ပါဘူး၊ မန္တလေးမှာနေတယ်။

Ma-houq-pa-bú, Man-da-lé-hma né-deh.

No, he lives in Mandalay.

● မိသားစုက အရေးကြီးဆုံးပဲနော်။

Mi-tha-su-ga a-yé-cí-zoun-béh-naw.

Family's the most important thing, huh.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-27

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Multi-generational households are common, and asking after someone's parents specifically is a real sign of respect and care, not small talk filler. Family is generally treated as the most stable, most important reference point in a conversation — you'll notice Ko Aung says as much outright in this unit.

03 • VOCABULARY

အဖေ a-p'é

father

အမေ a-mé

mother

အကို a-ko

older brother

အမ a-ma

older sister

ညီ nyi

younger brother

ညီမ nyi-ma

younger sister

မောင် maun

younger brother (of a woman)

ရှိသေးတယ် shi-dhé-

deh

to still be alive / still there

04 • GRAMMAR

-dhé — "still"

Attach -dhé (voiced from -thé) before -deh to mean "still": shi-dhé-deh, "[they are] still there / still alive." A gentle, important suffix for asking about elderly relatives respectfully.

ရှိသေးတယ်။ Shi-dhé-deh. Still living.

အလုပ်လုပ်နေသေးတယ်။

A-louq louq-né-dhé-deh. Still working.

ရ

ရ curls in the opposite direction from

ယ — same fluid energy, mirrored.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in

Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.



Feelings and small talk

လ (la)

Say how you're feeling and keep a casual conversation moving.

01 • MAIN

● ဒီခရီးစဉ် ပျော်နေလား။

Di k'a-yi-zin pyaw-né-la.

Are you enjoying this trip?

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ သိပ်ပျော်ပါတယ်။

Houq-keh, théiq pyaw-ba-deh.

Yes, I'm really enjoying it.

● ပင်ပန်းနေသလား။

Pin-ban-né-dha-la.

Are you tired?

● အနည်းငယ်ပင်ပန်းပါတယ်၊ ဒါပေမဲ့ ပျော်ပါတယ်။

A-né-ngeh pin-ban-ba-deh, da-bé-méh pyaw-ba-deh.

A little tired, but I'm happy.

● စိတ်ညစ်စရာရှိလား။

Seiq-nyiq-za-ya shi-la.

Anything bothering you?

● မရှိပါဘူး၊ အားလုံးကောင်းပါတယ်။
Ma-shi-ba-bú, a-loun-kaun-ba-deh.
No, everything's good.

● ဒါဆို အေးဆေးနေပါ။
Da-hso é-zé-né-ba.
Then just relax.

● ကျေးဇူးတင်ပါတယ်၊ နှစ်ယောက်လုံး။
Cé-zú-tin-ba-deh, hna-yauq-loun.
Thank you, both of you.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-28

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Burmese conversation tends to keep an even, harmonious surface — genuine tiredness, stress, or worry is often understated ("a little tired" instead of "exhausted") rather than displayed openly. Reading past the understatement, and responding with the same gentle check-in Su does here, is more useful than taking the words at face value.

03 • VOCABULARY

ပျော်တယ် pyaw-deh
to be happy

စိတ်ညစ်တယ် seiq-nyiq-teh
to be upset

-နေတယ် -né-deh
(continuous / right now)

ပူပန်တယ် pu-ban-deh
to worry

ပင်ပန်းတယ် pin-ban-deh
to be tired

စိတ်လှုပ်ရှားတယ် seiq-hlouq-sha-deh
to be excited

အနည်းငယ် a-né-ngeh
a little

အေးဆေးတယ် é-zé-deh

04 • GRAMMAR

-né-deh — happening right now

Insert -né- before -deh to mark an action or state as continuous, in progress right now: pin-ban-né-deh, "[I] am tired [right now]," versus the timeless pin-ban-deh, "to be a tiring sort of thing."

ပင်ပန်းနေတယ်။ Pin-ban-né-deh.

I'm tired (right now).

အလုပ်လုပ်နေတယ်။ A-louq louq-né-deh.

I'm working (right now).



A single wide loop, low and rounded — one of the more forgiving letters to write at speed.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in

Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

Making plans

○ (wa)

Suggest meeting up and check whether someone's free.

01 • MAIN

● မနက်ဖြန်အားလား။

Ma-neq-p'yan a-la.

Are you free tomorrow?

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ အားပါတယ်။

Houq-keh, a-ba-deh.

Yes, I'm free.

● ဒါဆို ညနေမှာတွေ့ကြရအောင်။

Da-hso nya-né-hma twé-ca-ya-aun.

Then let's meet in the evening.

● ဘယ်မှာတွေ့မလဲ။

Beh-hma twé-ma-lé.

Where should we meet?

● ဒီကော်ဖီဆိုင်မှာပဲ တွေ့ကြရအောင်။

Di kaw-p'i-s'ain-hma-béh twé-ca-ya-aun.

Let's just meet at this café.

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ ရပါတယ်။

Houq-keh, ya-ba-deh.

Okay, that works.

● ငါဖုန်းခေါ်ပါ့မယ်။

Nga p'oun k'aw-ba-meh.

I'll call.

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ မနက်ဖြန်တွေ့မယ်။

Houq-keh, ma-neq-p'yan twé-meh.

Alright, see you tomorrow.

● မနက်ဖြန်တွေ့မယ်။

Ma-neq-p'yan twé-meh.

See you tomorrow.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-29

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Two things worth knowing. On the phone, Burmese speakers commonly answer with Alo? (a loan from "hello," used only for phone calls — never in person). And on invitations: a specific plan with a place and rough time, like this unit's, is a real invitation meant to happen. A vaguer "come by sometime" offered in passing is often closer to warmth than a commitment — the way "we should get lunch sometime" often works in English. If you're not sure which one you've been given, it's completely fine to ask directly, or suggest a specific time yourself and see what happens.

03 • VOCABULARY

မနက်ဖြန် ma-neq-p'yan

tomorrow

ဒီနေ့ di-né

today

မနေ့က ma-né-ga

yesterday

အားတယ် a-deh

to be free (available)

ညနေ nya-né

evening

-ရအောင် -ya-aun

let's...

ဖုန်းခေါ်ပါ့မယ် p'oun

k'aw-ba-meh

I'll call you

ချိန်းတယ် c'ein-deh

to make an appointment

-ya-aun — a soft "let's"

Twé-ca-ya-aun ("let's meet") uses -ya-aun on the verb — a gentle suggestion, not a command. It invites agreement the way -naw invites agreement on a statement, but on an action instead.

သွားရအောင်။ Thwa-ya-aun. Let's go.

စားရအောင်။ Sa-ya-aun. Let's eat.



A simple, near-perfect circle — one continuous stroke, no corners.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in

Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

Weather and time

သ (tha (sa))

Talk about the weather and what time it is.

01 • MAIN

● ဒီနေ့မိုးရွာမလား။

Di-né mo ywa-ma-la.

Will it rain today?

● ရွာလိမ့်ပါတယ်၊ ညနေဆို။

Ywa-lein-ba-deh, nya-né-hso.

Looks like it, come evening.

● အခုဘယ်နှစ်နာရီရှိပြီလဲ။

A-k'u beh-hna-na-yi shi-bi-lé.

What time is it now?

● ငါးနာရီရှိပါပြီ။

Ngá-na-yi shi-ba-bi.

It's five o'clock.

● ဒါဆို မိုးမရွာခင် ပြန်ကြရအောင်။

Da-hso mo-ma-ywa-gin pyan-ca-ya-aun.

Then let's head back before it rains.

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ လိုက်ပို့ပေးမယ်။

Houq-keh, laiq-po-pé-meh.

Okay, I'll walk you back.

● ခုနက ပူတာနဲ့ အခုအေးသွားပြီနော်။

K'u-na-ga pu-da-néh a-k'u é-thwa-bi-naw.

It was hot earlier, and now it's gotten cool, huh.

● ဟုတ်တယ်၊ ရာသီဥတု အပြန်ပြောင်းတာပဲ။

Houq-teh, ya-thi-u-du a-myan pyaun-da-béh.

True, the weather changes fast here.

● မြန်မာမှာ ဒီလိုပါပဲ။

Myan-ma-hma di-lo ba-béh.

That's just how it is in Myanmar.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-30

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Plans and daily rhythms often bend around the weather and the lunar calendar more than the clock — many holidays and events are set by the Buddhist calendar rather than a fixed Gregorian date. Treat scheduled times as reasonably loose by default, in both directions.

03 • VOCABULARY

မိုး mo

rain

နေ né

sun

လေ lé

wind

နာရီ na-yi

o'clock

ရာသီဥတု ya-thi-u-du

weather / season

ရွာတယ် ywa-deh

to rain

ပူအိုက်တယ် pu-aiq-teh

to be muggy

အေးစက်တယ် é-seq-

teh

to be freezing cold

04 • GRAMMAR

Number + na-yi — telling time

Just like counting people (Unit 5) or money (Unit 6), time uses a classifier: number + na-yi means "o'clock." Ngá-na-yi = "five o'clock," following the exact same number-classifier pattern you've used all book.

ငါးနာရီရှိပြီ။ Ngá-na-yi shi-bi.

It's five o'clock already.

-lein — "looks like / seems"

Ywa-lein-ba-deh ("looks like rain") uses -lein to soften a prediction — you're guessing based on evidence, not stating a fact outright.

မိုးရွာလိမ့်မယ်။ Mo ywa-lein-meh.

It looks like it'll rain.



A large loop with a tail curling under — a very common, distinctive shape you'll see everywhere in running text.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in

Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

Health and emergencies

ဟ (ha)

Get help fast when something goes wrong.

01 • MAIN

A short scare — a headache turns out to be nothing serious, but it's the moment you realize how far Ko Aung and Su are willing to go for a friend they've known less than a week.

● ခေါင်းကိုက်နေတယ်။

Gaun kaiq-né-deh.

I have a headache.

● ဘာဖြစ်လဲ။ နေမကောင်းဘူးလား။

Ba-p'yi-q-lé. Né-ma-kaun-bu-la.

What's wrong? Are you not feeling well?

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ နည်းနည်းမကောင်းဘူး။

Houq-keh, né-né ma-kaun-bu.

Yeah, a little unwell.

● ကျွန်တော် ဆေးရုံခေါ်သွားပေးမယ်။

Ca-na-w hsé-youn k'aw-thwa-pé-meh.

I'll take you to the hospital.

● ကျေးဇူးတင်ပါတယ်။

Cé-zú-tin-ba-deh.

Thank you.

● စိတ်မပူပါနဲ့၊ ကျွန်မတို့ ရှိတယ်။

Seiq-ma-pu-ba-néh, ca-ma-dó shi-deh.

Don't worry, we're here.

● ကားပေါ်တက်ပါ။

Ka-paw teq-pa.

Get in the car.

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ ကျေးဇူးအများကြီး။

Houq-keh, cé-zú a-mya-cí.

Okay, thank you so much.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-31

02 • CULTURE NOTE

What you're seeing in this unit — near-strangers dropping everything to help — isn't exaggerated for the story. A strong communal expectation to help someone in visible trouble, especially a guest, runs deep, and people will often go further than you'd think to ask for, or expect.

03 • VOCABULARY

ကူညီပါ ku-nyi-ba
help!

ရဲ yeh
police

ခေါင်း gaun
head

အရေးပေါ် a-yé-paw
emergency

ဆေးရုံ hsé-youn
hospital

ကိုက်တယ် kaiq-teh
to ache

အန္တရာယ် an-da-yeh
danger

နာတယ် na-deh
to hurt / to be in pain

04 • GRAMMAR

kaiq-teh — the go-to word for aches

Body part + kaiq-teh ("to ache") covers almost any everyday pain: gaun kaiq-teh (headache), wun kaiq-teh

(stomachache). Simple, high-frequency, and exactly what you need in an emergency.

ခေါင်းကိုက်တယ်။ Gaun kaiq-teh.

I have a headache.

ဗိုက်ကိုက်တယ်။ Wun kaiq-teh.

I have a stomachache.

t'wa-pé-ba — "please take (me)"

T'wa-pé-ba ("please take/lead me there") combines with a place using -ko or -go: hsé-youn-go t'wa-pé-ba, or simply drop the marker in an urgent, clipped sentence, as above.

ဆေးရုံခေါ်သွားပေးပါ။

Hsé-youn k'aw-thwa-pé-ba.

Please take me to the hospital.

ဟ

A tall loop with a straight leg down the right — write the loop first, then drop the leg without lifting the pen.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in

Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.



Apologies

ဇ (la (great))

Apologize sincerely and accept an apology graciously.

01 • MAIN

- အနှောင့်အယှက်ဖြစ်စေလို့ တောင်းပန်ပါတယ်။

A-hnaung-a-sheq p'yi-q-sé-lo taun-ban-ba-deh.

I'm sorry for the trouble I caused.

- ကိစ္စမရှိပါဘူး။

Kiq-sa ma-shi-ba-bú.

No problem at all.

- သူငယ်ချင်းအချင်းချင်း ဒါလောက်တော့ လုပ်ရမှာပေါ့။

Thu-ngeh-jin a-chin-jin da-lauq-daw louq-ya-hma-paw.

That's what friends do.

- ကျွန်တော်တမင်မဟုတ်ပါဘူး။

Ca-na-w ta-min ma-houq-pa-bú.

It wasn't on purpose, of course.

- သိပါတယ်၊ စိတ်မညစ်ပါနဲ့။

Thi-ba-deh, sei-q-ma-nyiq-pa-néh.

We know, don't worry about it.

- အခု ပိုကောင်းလာဖူး။

A-k'u po-kaun-la-bya.

Feeling better now?

● ဟုတ်ကဲ့၊ သိပ်ကောင်းသွားပါပြီ။
Houq-keh, théiq kaun-thwa-ba-bi.
Yes, much better now.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-32

02 · CULTURE NOTE

Direct correction or confrontation in front of others is generally avoided in favor of a private, gentle word — public apologies or callouts can cause more embarrassment than the original problem. A quiet, sincere taun-ban-ba-deh, like Unit 32 teaches, usually closes the matter completely; there's rarely a need to revisit it.

03 · VOCABULARY

တောင်းပန်တယ် taun-
ban-deh
to apologize

အမှား a-hma
mistake

ခွင့်လွှတ်တယ် k'win-
hlouq-teh
to forgive

ကိစ္စမရှိပါဘူး kiq-sa
ma-shi-ba-bú
no problem / it's alright

နောက်တစ်ခါ nauq-ta-
k'a
next time

တမင်မဟုတ်ပါဘူး ta-
min ma-houq-pa-bú
it wasn't on purpose

04 · GRAMMAR

A rare letter, a common courtesy

ၵ appears in almost no modern words — it's kept mainly in Pali-derived spellings — but the phrase this unit teaches, taun-ban-ba-deh, is something you'll want ready in any language, any day.

တောင်းပန်ပါတယ်။ Taun-ban-ba-deh .

I'm sorry / I apologize.

၁၁

Shares ௐ's loop with a small extra curl added. Write ௐ, then add the flourish without breaking stroke.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in

Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.

UNIT 33 အ

Saying goodbye — and review

အ (a)

Close a conversation warmly, and look back at everything Book 1 covered.

01 • MAIN

A month ago you landed in Yangon knowing four words. Today you're saying goodbye to two friends, in their language, without translating a single sentence in your head first.

• သွားတော့မယ်နော်။

Thwa-daw-meh-naw.

I'm heading off now.

• ပြန်တွေ့ကြမယ်။

Pyan-twé-ca-meh.

See you again.

• တစ်ခါလာရင် ငါ့ဆီဆက်ခေါ်ပါ။

Ta-k'a la-yin ngat-si seq-k'aw-pa.

Whenever you come again, call me up.

• ကျေးဇူးအများကြီး၊ နှစ်ယောက်လုံး။

Cé-zú a-mya-cí, hna-yauq-loun.

Thank you so much, both of you.

• မြန်မာစာ တော်တော်တိုးတက်သွားပြီနော်။

Myan-ma-sa taw-taw to-teq-thwa-bi-naw.

Your Burmese has really improved, hasn't it.

• ပထမနေ့ကနေ အခုထိ ကြည့်ပါ။

Pa-t'a-ma-né-ga-né a-k'u-t'i cí-ba.

Look how far you've come since day one.

● ကျေးဇူးတင်ပါတယ်၊ နှစ်ယောက်လုံးကြောင့်ပါ။

Cé-zú-tin-ba-deh, hna-yauq-loun-caun-ba.

Thank you — it's thanks to both of you.

● သွားလာပါဦးမယ်။

Thwa-la-ba-oun-meh.

Take care — I'll be on my way too.

● ကျန်းမာပါစေ။

Kyan-ma-ba-zé.

Stay well.

Audio for this unit: bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html#unit-33

02 • CULTURE NOTE

Burmese goodbyes tend to include a reciprocal blessing — kyan-ma-ba-zé ("stay well/healthy") rather than a bare "bye" — which is why Ko Aung closes with it here. And when a real friend says "call me next time you're here," as he does, it's almost always meant sincerely, not as a farewell formality — which is the real answer to a question from early in the book: how do you tell a genuine invitation from a polite one? By the time you reach here, you'll likely already know the difference by ear.

03 • VOCABULARY

နှုတ်ဆက်တယ် hnouq-

seq-teh

to say goodbye

ပြန်တွေ့မယ် pyan-twé-

meh

see you again

ကျေးဇူးအများကြီး cé-

zú a-mya-cí

နှစ်ဆယ့်သုံး hna-zeh-

thoun

thank you so much

ဒါဆိုရင် da-hso-yin

in that case / so then

twenty-three (bonus number!)

တွေ့ရတာဝမ်းသာပါ

တယ် twé-ya-da wun-

tha-ba-deh

it was nice meeting you

04 • GRAMMAR

The whole sentence engine, in one look back

You've now met every consonant, and every core sentence-ending you need: -deh (state it), -naw (invite agreement), -ba-/ -pa- (say it politely), ma-...-bú (say no), -tha-la/-dha-la (ask plainly), -lé (ask with a question word), -meh (say what will happen), -bi (say it's already so), and -né- (say it's happening right now).

ပူတယ်။ ပူတယ်နော်။ ပူပါတယ်။ မပူပါဘူး။ ပူ
သလား။ ဘာလဲ။ ပူမယ်။ ပူပြီ။ ပူနေတယ်။

Pu-deh. Pu-deh-naw. Pu-ba-deh. Ma-pu-ba-bú.
Pu-tha-la. Ba-lé. Pu-meh. Pu-bi. Pu-né-deh.

It's hot. Hot, isn't it? It's hot (polite). It's not hot. Is it hot?
What is it? It'll be hot. It's (now) hot. It's (currently) hot.

အ

အ stands alone — the only letter that's also a full vowel carrier by itself. A closed loop with a short tail, closing the set you opened in Unit 1.

See the Stroke Practice Sheet (John Okell) in Downloads for real stroke-direction arrows.



Keep going

The full interactive version of this book — with audio as it's added, and progress tracking — lives at **bamalearnburmese.com/book1.html**. More cheatsheets and resources:

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